to bed. When we met the next morning, he handed over a concise brief answering the previous evening's question. I was impressed by his dedication. Ajai had been nominated to make a presentation during the Army Commanders' Conference on light tanks, their role, capabilities and relevance in the Indian context. He showed me his presentation, which had too much detail. The Army Commanders already knew the background and would be briefed on this topic before the conference. Stating the obvious would be superfluous, particularly when half of them were Armoured Corps officers. I told him to just concentrate on the last part, the relevance in the Indian context, and to force a decision. Do we need them or not? Ajai reworked his presentation, cutting it down by half, and he told me later that it had been well received. Nothing much came out of it though, and it needed a crisis to get the light tank centre stage again. Work on the light tank 'Zorawar' has now commenced post the Ladakh crisis of 2020.

Ajai had also decided to enrol himself for a PhD programme at the Punjabi University, Patiala. As per the rules, anyone wanting to pursue higher studies had to take permission from his immediate superior officer; in this case, from me. This is not a restrictive clause but actually exists to protect the student, whether an officer or a jawan. By granting permission, the organization is also committing itself to grant leave to the individual whenever required, for examinations or field trips, even if they conflict with official engagements. When Ajai came to me to take the formal permission, I casually mentioned how it was a good thing that he was doing and how I wished I could do the same. Ajai immediately swung into action. I had left the next day for an outstation visit, but he took all the requisite details from my PA, Hav SK Tiwari, filled up the forms online and even made the payment from his own pocket. When I

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation